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News



PHOTO COURTESY OF WIRED

University of Memphis graduate student Andrew Olney sits with the life-like Philip K. Dick robot.

Life-sized robot on display at FedEx Institute of Technology

by Trey Heath

Staff Reporter

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One of the world's most expressive robots will soon be on display at the FedEx Institute of Technology.

Researchers from The University of Memphis FedEx Institute, as well as scientists from Hanson Robotics and the University of Texas at Arlington, have been developing a robotic likeness of the acclaimed science fiction author Phillip K Dick.

Dick, who is mostly known for creating the fiction behind the popular movies "Blade Runner," "Minority Report," "Paycheck," and "Total Recall," has been reborn in a life-sized robotic creation. The robot will be on display at the FedEx Institute of Technology from June 30 to July 8.

Researchers, including U of M graduate student Andrew Olney, are developing the project for one of the main displays in WIRED magazine's NextFest in Chicago June 23-26.

The robot will feature new advancements in natural language, artificial intelligence and machine vision that allow the creation to actually carry on a conversation with a human and will be displayed in a 70's-style Californian set built by The U of M's Theater and Fine Arts Department.

Cameras set in the machine's eyes allow the robot to track faces and recognize people, while visual data gathered is fused with speech recognition and speech synthesis software.

The developments enable the machine to listen, understand, and respond to someone talking to it or asking questions.

The robot can provide simple answers such as "yes" or "fine" or longer explanations derived from thousands of pages of text copied into the machine's head from Dick's many writings.

All of these advancements are accented by research provided by Hanson Engineering's creation of a life-like skin that can show a full range of human emotions.

"It is a testament to researchers' quality of research and work," said Marcy Sanford, U of M marketing manager. "The project is allowing the Institute to get its name out there and bring prestige to The University."

The project is already attracting large amounts of attention from several large major media outlets, Sanford said.

"We are hoping to get The Today Show to feature a story on the project," Sanford said.

The Discovery Channel has already made plans to feature the project Sunday at 1 p.m. on a program covering NextFest.

After the robot makes its debut in Chicago, U of M students will get a chance to see and talk to the personal robot in the lobby of the Institute.

"We are planning on setting up times in which students can actually talk to the machine," Sanford said.

Talking to the likeness of a well-known dead author is definitely something new to summer school for biology major Brian Lyle.

"Sounds like there will be a lot more to do in the FedEx Institute than drink coffee," said Lyle.